Step 2 — Customer Lookups That Run at the Same Time — Solution

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Story — Step 2: a good billing or technical reply needs the customer's account and recent orders. Those are two separate lookups, and neither needs the other's result — so there's no reason to wait for one before starting the other. This step adds both lookups, first one after another, then in parallel, and measures the difference. **If not:** every billing ticket would wait twice as long as it needs to, for no benefit.

After this step the project runs: billing and technical replies use the account and order details, and `python -m scripts.time_lookups` shows about 2 s one after another vs. about 1 s in parallel. Files not shown here don't change.

Changed first

Changed from Step 1: the billing and technical prompts now have `{account}` and `{orders}` slots. `general.txt` doesn't change — a general question needs no account data.

`src/prompts/billing.txt`

```
You are a billing support agent at SupportCo. Write a short, polite
reply to the customer, under 120 words. Use the account and order
details below. Never promise a refund: say the billing team will
check the charge within 2 business days.

Account: {account}
Recent orders: {orders}

Ticket: {ticket}
```

`src/prompts/technical.txt`

```
You are a technical support agent at SupportCo. Write a short, polite
reply to the customer, under 120 words. Suggest one or two simple
things to try, and ask for one missing detail (browser, device or
steps) if you need it. Use the account details below.
```

```
Account: {account}
Recent orders: {orders}

Ticket: {ticket}
```

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Solution — both lookups at the same time with `RunnableParallel`

Story — `chains/lookups.py`: the same two lookups, plus `get_ticket_text()` to carry the ticket through. `build_lookup_step()` puts all three in a `RunnableParallel`: every function gets the same input, they run at the same time, and the result is a dict with the same keys (Doc05's LCEL topic: "a dict becomes a step that runs each value in parallel"). **If not:** the wait grows with every lookup you add.

```
# src/chains/lookups.py
# Stand-in customer lookups. get_account_info/get_order_history each wait
# LOOKUP_DELAY_SECONDS like a real network call; build_lookup_step() runs
# all three lookups at the same time with RunnableParallel.
import time

from langchain_core.runnables import RunnableParallel

FAKE_ACCOUNTS = {
    "C-1001": "Pro plan, customer since 2023-04-12",
    "C-1002": "Basic plan, customer since 2024-11-03",
    "C-1003": "Pro plan, customer since 2022-01-20",
    "C-1004": "Team plan, customer since 2025-06-30",
}
FAKE_ORDERS = {
    "C-1001": "INV-2201 $29 on 2026-09-01, INV-2202 $29 on 2026-09-01",
    "C-1002": "INV-1870 $9 on 2026-09-03",
    "C-1004": "INV-2310 $99 on 2026-09-05",
}
LOOKUP_DELAY_SECONDS = 1

def get_ticket_text(inputs):
    return inputs["ticket"]

def get_account_info(inputs):
    time.sleep(LOOKUP_DELAY_SECONDS)
    customer_id = inputs["customer_id"]
    if customer_id in FAKE_ACCOUNTS:
        return FAKE_ACCOUNTS[customer_id]
    return "No account found for this customer."

def get_order_history(inputs):
    time.sleep(LOOKUP_DELAY_SECONDS)
```

```
    customer_id = inputs["customer_id"]
    if customer_id in FAKE_ORDERS:
        return FAKE_ORDERS[customer_id]
    return "No recent orders."

def build_lookup_step():
    return RunnableParallel(
        {
            "ticket": get_ticket_text,
            "account": get_account_info,
            "orders": get_order_history,
        }
    )
```

Changed from Step 1: billing and technical chains start with the lookup step. General stays as it was.

Story — `chains/replies.py`: the lookup step's dict (`ticket`, `account`, `orders`) fills the prompt directly — its keys match the prompt's slots on purpose. **If not:** you'd need glue code to rename keys between the two steps.

```
# src/chains/replies.py
# build_reply_chain(category): one reply chain per category. Billing and
# technical run the parallel lookups first; general needs no account data.
from langchain_core.output_parsers import StrOutputParser
from langchain_core.prompts import ChatPromptTemplate

from src.chains.lookups import build_lookup_step     # new in Step 2
from src.models.llm import get_model
from src.utils.prompts import load_prompt

def build_reply_chain(category):
    prompt = ChatPromptTemplate.from_template(load_prompt(category))
    chain = prompt | get_model() | StrOutputParser()

    # new in Step 2: lookups before billing/technical, not general
    if category == "general":
        full_chain = chain
    else:
        full_chain = build_lookup_step() | chain

    return full_chain
```

Story — `scripts/time_lookups.py`: the proof. It times the two lookups one after another, then the parallel step, and prints both numbers. **If not:** "it's faster" would be a claim, not a measurement.

```
# scripts/time_lookups.py
# Times the two customer lookups one after another, then in parallel, and
# prints both. No API key needed.
# Run from the repo root: python -m scripts.time_lookups
import time

from src.chains.lookups import (
    build_lookup_step,
    get_account_info,
    get_order_history,
)

def main():
    inputs = {"ticket": "test ticket", "customer_id": "C-1001"}

    start = time.time()
    get_account_info(inputs)
    get_order_history(inputs)
    one_by_one = time.time() - start

    start = time.time()
    build_lookup_step().invoke(inputs)
    in_parallel = time.time() - start

    print(f"one after another: {one_by_one:.1f} s")
    print(f"in parallel:       {in_parallel:.1f} s")

if __name__ == "__main__":
    main()
```

Story — `tests/unit/test_lookups.py`: known and unknown customers, the three keys, and a time check — all with no API key, each printing `OK` or `WRONG`. **If not:** a later change could quietly make the lookups run one after another again.

```
# tests/unit/test_lookups.py
# Checks the fake lookups and that the lookup step runs them in parallel.
# Each case prints OK or WRONG. No API key needed.
# Run from the repo root: python -m tests.unit.test_lookups
import time

from src.chains.lookups import (
    build_lookup_step,
    get_account_info,
    get_order_history,
)
```

```
def test_known_customer():
    inputs = {"ticket": "hi", "customer_id": "C-1001"}
    ok = "OK"
    if "Pro plan" not in get_account_info(inputs):
        ok = "WRONG"
    if "INV-2201" not in get_order_history(inputs):
        ok = "WRONG"
    print(f"case 1 (known customer)  -> {ok}")


def test_unknown_customer():
    inputs = {"ticket": "hi", "customer_id": "C-9999"}
    ok = "OK"
    if "No account found" not in get_account_info(inputs):
        ok = "WRONG"
    if "No recent orders" not in get_order_history(inputs):
        ok = "WRONG"
    print(f"case 2 (unknown customer) -> {ok}")


def test_lookup_step():
    inputs = {"ticket": "hi", "customer_id": "C-1002"}
    start = time.time()
    result = build_lookup_step().invoke(inputs)
    seconds = time.time() - start
    ok = "OK"
    if sorted(result.keys()) != ["account", "orders", "ticket"]:
        ok = "WRONG"
    # two 1-second lookups: about 1 s means they ran in parallel
    if seconds >= 1.5:
        ok = "WRONG"
    print(f"case 3 (parallel keys)   -> {ok}")


if __name__ == "__main__":
    test_known_customer()
    test_unknown_customer()
    test_lookup_step()
```

Run it (from the repo root):

```
python -m scripts.time_lookups
python -m tests.unit.test_lookups
python main.py
```

`scripts.time_lookups` prints:

```
one after another: 2.0 s
in parallel:       1.0 s
```

`test_lookups` prints:

```
case 1 (known customer)  -> OK
case 2 (unknown customer) -> OK
case 3 (parallel keys)   -> OK
```